

JOKES: IF YOU CAN UNDERSTAND THESE, YOU'RE ADVANCED!

In this exciting lesson, we explore the exciting world of play on words, puns and more. Although jokes may seem silly, they hold the key to unlocking advanced fluency. Whether you're a beginner or an advanced learner, mastering the multiple meanings of words and honing your comprehension skills is vital.

THE PUN

One of the most common forms of wordplay is the pun, and there are loads of pun-related content circulating around the internet. They are often referred to as 'dad jokes'.

A **pun** uses the multiple meanings of a term or similar-sounding word(s) for an intended humorous effect. Puns often rely on homophones, homographs or homonyms.

Word Type	Explanation	Examples
homophones	Words that have the same pronunciation but <i>different meanings</i> , origins or spelling. They can cause confusion in spoken language because they sound identical, so context is extremely important.	pair - a set of two pear - a type of fruit flour - an ingredient for baking flower - a blooming plant break - to separate into pieces brake - a device for slowing a vehicle
homographs	Words that have the same spelling but <i>different meanings</i> and may have different pronunciations and tend to cause confusion in writing.	bow - to bend at the waist bow - a decorative knot tear - to rip something tear - a drop of liquid from the eye lead - a type of metal lead - to guide or direct



homonyms	Words that have the same spelling and pronunciation but <i>different meanings</i> . Considered a combination of homophones and homographs and thus cause confusion in both speaking and writing.	bark - the outer covering of a tree bark - the sound a dog makes bank - a financial institution bank - the side of a river bat - a flying mammal bat - a piece of sports equipment
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FUN WITH PUNS

1

Did you hear about the guy whose whole left side was cut off?
He's **all right** now.

This absolutely hilarious pun plays on the *homophones* '**alright**' and '**all right**'.

The joke is that the man who had his left side cut off would be in a terrible state, but the punchline reveals that he is actually '**alright**' now, meaning he is **doing well** or **fine**. The pun relies on the double meaning of '**all right**', which means that he only has a right side now because his left side was removed. He consists only of his right side, so he is **ALL right**.

2

Did you hear about the bicycle that couldn't stand on its
own?
Yeah, it was **two-tyred**.



Here we have the *homophones* 'too tired' and 'two-tyred.' We need to understand that 'too tired' means exhausted while 'two-tyred' means having two wheels. The bike couldn't stand on its own because something with two tyres will obviously fall over, but you also might not be able to stand if you are exhausted. So... too tired. *Hilarious!*

3

Why are postmen so unhappy all the time?
Because they are *given the sack* every morning.

Now we can see how *homonyms* can also be used to make puns. Here we are playing with the double meaning of the phrase 'given the sack.' In this context, 'given the sack' means to be fired or dismissed from a job. The joke is that postmen are 'given the sack' every morning because they are given a bag or 'sack' to carry the post in.

4

My mum tried to make a joke about the TV,
but it wasn't *remotely* funny.

I guess this one is more of a 'mum joke', but here we are using the *double meaning* of the word 'remote.'

In this context, adding '-ly' to 'remote' makes the adverb '*remotely*', which means 'not at all'. The joke is that my mum tried to make a joke about the TV, but it wasn't 'remotely' funny—it wasn't funny at all. However, '*remote*' is also a shortened way to say remote control, which is a device used to change channels on a TV.

Pure comedic gold if you ask me!



5

There is a **fine line** between a numerator and a denominator. It's okay if you didn't get that — only a **fraction** will understand.

This is actually a two-for-one! We have two puns in one joke. First, in mathematics, a **fraction** is a numerical quantity that represents a part of a whole, expressed as a numerator over a denominator. The joke is that there is a '**fine line**', which is a reference to the horizontal line that separates them in a fraction, but '**fine line**' also means 'a very small difference'.

The second joke is that the word '**fraction**' means 'a small number' outside of its mathematical meaning. So, only a small number of people will understand the joke.

BONUS PUNS

- *I'm reading a book about anti-gravity. It's impossible to **put down**!*

This one uses the double meaning of 'put down.' The book is so interesting that you don't want to put it down, but also, anti-gravity means that things don't fall down, so the book literally can't be put down.

- *Why don't oysters give to charity? Because they're **shellfish**!*

This one plays with homophones. '**Selfish**' refers to someone who only thinks of themselves, which sounds an awful lot like '**shellfish**', which refers to the fact that oysters have shells.

- *What'd the grape say when it got stepped on? Nothing, it just let out a little **whine**.*

Another homophone! '**Whine**' is a play on words with '**wine**' since grapes are used to make wine. Also, when something hurts, it can make you '**whine**', which is a long, high-pitched, often unpleasant sound.



QUIZ!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

- 1) What is the term for words that have the same pronunciation but different meanings, origins or spelling?
 - a. homophones
 - b. homographs
 - c. homonyms
- 2) Which of the following pairs is an example of homophones?
 - a. sell and cell
 - b. bow and bow
 - c. park and bark
- 3) Homographs have the same _____ but different meanings and may have different pronunciations.
 - a. origins
 - b. pronunciation
 - c. spellings
- 4) What is the term for words that have the same spelling and pronunciation but different meanings?
 - a. homophones
 - b. homographs
 - c. homonyms
- 5) Puns often rely on which of the following?
 - a. synonyms
 - b. homophones
 - c. antonyms
- 6) Which of the following is a pun?
 - a. I used to be a baker, but I didn't make enough dough.
 - b. Why did the chicken cross the road? To get to the other side.
 - c. She's as hungry as a lion!
- 7) Based on what you've learnt about puns, which of the following is a characteristic of a well-crafted pun?
 - a. They make people angry.
 - b) They are easily understood by everyone.
 - c) They require play on words to create a humorous effect.
- 8) Complete the pun.

The maths book looked sad because it had too many _____.

 - a. questions
 - b. problems
 - c. equations

The End!

(1 a 2 a 3 c 4 c 5 a 6 a 7 c 8 b)

